

Q What simple exercises can I try at home?

Recommended by midwives, these exercises are easy to do at home. However, check with your doctor first that they are safe in your specific case. Stop if you feel any discomfort or dizziness.

HAND STRETCHES

Try these simple stretches if you feel pain, tingling, or numbness in your hands.

» **Shake your hands for one minute** as if air-drying them after just washing them.

» **For a deep stretch**, hold out one arm, keep your elbow straight, and drop your wrist so your fingers face the floor. Using your other hand, apply gentle pressure to the back of your hand to gently stretch your wrist and fingers for 20 seconds. Repeat with the other hand.

» **Put your hands together in a prayer position.** Spread your fingers, then pull your palms as far apart as possible while keeping your fingertips together. Repeat several times.



FOOT STRETCHES

Relieve foot cramps and ease any arch strain, or even plantar fasciitis, with this exercise.

» **Foot roll** Stand in bare feet on a nonslip surface. Roll a tennis ball or golf ball around under the base of one foot for two minutes to gently massage all the muscles. Repeat with the other foot.



BACK STRETCHES

Keep your spine flexible by warming up and strengthening the muscles around it. Kneeling on all fours also helps to relieve tension in your spine.



1 Kneel on the floor, then lean forward and support your weight on your straightened arms (don't lock your elbows), so that you're on all fours. Keep your hands, knees, and feet in line with each other. Keep your back horizontal. Relax your neck and inhale.



2 Slowly draw up your abdominal muscles as you exhale, tuck your pelvis under, and lengthen the base of your spine gently so your back is arched like that of a cat. Keep your elbows gently straight, but not locked. Inhale and release to straighten your back again; be careful not to hollow out your back.

3 Repeat the arching movement ten times altogether. When you've finished, sit back on your heels and breathe deeply a few times to relax. Get up slowly so you don't feel dizzy.

SPINE STRETCHES

As your baby grows heavier, it's beneficial to align and stretch your spine every day. Try these two simple exercises to relax and refresh you.

1 Stand with your feet hip-width apart just in front of a wall. Bend your knees slightly and rest the length of your spine against the wall. Breathe deeply.

2 When you're ready, breathe out and pull your belly button toward your spine. Your pelvis should tilt up and away from the wall slightly, so that your lower back presses into the wall. Hold briefly, then inhale and release. Repeat ten times.

Pelvic tilt Raise your hips up and out to flatten your back against the wall

Spine alignment Rest the length of your back against the wall



Feet flat on floor

Ease discomfort and stabilize your back using these **stretching** and **strengthening** techniques.